

NEWCASTLE DIOCESE.

OPENING OF SYNOD.

FIRST SESSION.

THE BISHOP'S ADDRESS.

The first session of the twenty-first Synod of the Diocese of Newcastle was opened yesterday.

Proceedings were commenced by the celebration of Holy Communion at 10.30 a.m. at the Newcastle Cathedral, the Very Rev. Dr. H. Crotty, Dean of Newcastle, being the celebrant, Archdeacon Saxon, the Epistoller, and Archdeacon Woodd, the Gospeller. The Right Rev. Dr. Stephen, Bishop of Newcastle, was also present. The service was fully choral, being taken to Marbeck's familiar setting. Mr. T. H. Massey, Cathedral organist, accompanied the service on the organ. There was a large number of communicants.

At noon Synod reassembled in the Cathedral, when the Right Rev. Dr. Stephen, Bishop of the diocese, delivered his charge from the chancel steps, members of the Chapter being in attendance with him.

The bishop expressed the sympathy of Synod for the Primate, who had been suffering from serious illness, and a hope for his restoration to health. He also referred with regret to the deaths of Mr. Henry Croaker, Mr. John Hyland, Mr. C. W. King, and Mr. Hudson Berkeley, whose interest in the church and his willingness to work for it were backed up by contributions on a most generous scale. The sympathy of Synod also went out to the sufferers by the terrible disaster at the Bellbird Colliery, and was thankful for the splendid heroism shown by the rescue party. He referred to the many generous gifts received during the past year, including those of £14,000 from Mr. Hudson Berkeley, £500 from Commander Gardner, £1000 from Mrs. Doyle, on condition of the establishment of a theological college, £200 from Messrs. H. E. and V. White, and £100 from Miss Tighe towards the endowment fund of the Morpeth Boys' Home, and £500 by the Parnell family towards the Warriors' Chapel. After referring to the activity in the way of building new churches and halls in the diocese, the Bishop said that while there was a good record, the contributions towards diocesan funds still showed little advance, though the demands upon them were constantly increasing. The contributions to missions also fell short. They were asked for an increase of £300 this year, and to raise this should be well within their powers. He had been advised to postpone the establishment of a maternity hospital for the diocese, and he reluctantly accepted the advice, but thought there was great necessity for a girls' home. Already nearly £800 had been given or promised for the purpose, but about £6000 would be required, which he hoped would be provided before the end of the year.

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NOTE: THE BISHOP OF THE DIOCESE.

The diocese had been fortunate in securing the services of the Rev. J. R. Norman as director of education. They had decided to give candidates for ordination a year or two of training before they went to St. John's College. A home had been bought at Adamstown, and they now had four men under instruction.

A conference to consider the best way to secure self government of the church in Australia was to meet in 1926, and it was desirable to provide that the persons chosen as their representatives should also represent them at the conference. The Church of England was engaged in a much-needed revision of the Book of Common Prayer. They were concerned as much as those in England, but they could not express their views. "When the revised book is finished," the Bishop said, "we can take it or leave it. But the result may be more disastrous than a mere revision would suggest. Hitherto the Prayer Book has been a bond of union. It may become a solvent of our unity. Although it is not quite decided, it would seem that the strength of party spirit in England will make it necessary to provide alternative uses in the service for the Holy Communion. It may be necessary, but it is none the less deplorable. And here the position will be even worse. Each diocese can choose either the old book or the new book, or such portions of the new book as it thinks fit. Nor should I like to give a hasty judgment as to the rights of the individual priest to make his own selection. It is obvious that great and irritating diversity may be found in our forms of worship. As far as this diocese is concerned, I have great hopes that common sense and loyalty will lead us all to agree that once form, and one form only, shall be used. But it is not too soon for us all to learn something of the reasons why revision is needed, and the principles upon which it is based."

THE PROBLEM OF SUNDAY

"The thought of the form of worship leads naturally to what we call the day of worship. One of the great practical difficulties that confront us as a Church is connected with the observance of Sunday. The strictness of the past has disappeared. With the mass of our people, church-going is less frequent, the day is often wholly occupied in the pursuit of pleasure, and the modern tendency, both here and in the mother country, is towards greater laxity. It is no new thing in the history of the Church. There have been ages of laxity in the past, and the Church has survived. But it is one of the dangers of the day, and it must be faced. What then are we to

one of the dangers of the day, and it must be faced. What then are we to do with regard to this widespread movement? For ourselves we have probably formed our habits, whether they be right or wrong. But a three-fold problem remains. How should children, while they are still under the control of their parents, be trained in regard to Sunday? What advice should we give to our young people who are just entering on an independent life? And thirdly, what is our duty as citizens, when an institution of great social value seems threatened with ruin? On this third point I do not propose to speak, but the question of the duty of Christian parents remains. Now merely to denounce the tendency to secularise Sunday is as futile as it is easy. What we want is to find some principle, to which as Christians we can appeal, and on which we can base both our conduct and our advice.

"We turn to the New Testament, and we look in vain for any authoritative rule. There is no recorded word of Christ, there is no word of any of the Apostles, which tells us how we should keep Sunday, or indeed that we should keep it at all. It is disappointing, for it would make our task much easier if we could point to a definite rule, which left us no option but simple obedience or disobedience. But we must seek some other path. Go back to the story of the infant Church. They were faced with four needs, one arising from their nature as men, the other three from their nature as Christians. Because they were men they must needs worship God. But because they were Christians they must needs worship together. The Church is not a mere collection of individuals, it is essentially a brotherhood, and its very existence depends on the expression and development of this fellowship. And so the first thing the church had to do was to secure the life of fellowship by meetings, in which the human need for worship found expression in Christian, that is, in united worship. For these meetings a day must be chosen. There could be little doubt as to the most suitable day. The day of their Lord's victory over death, the day of His appearance to strengthen, and teach His friends, the day on which,

His Spirit came to carry on His work, in preference to this what day could the Christian brotherhood choose for their assemblies? Then the form and mode of worship must be chosen, and this was decided by our Lord's command. 'Do this in remembrance of Me,' was His word, and therefore Holy Communion became the central point of Christian worship. And so Sunday became the Christian festival. The first Christians worshipped because they were human. They worshipped together because they were brothers and must express their fellowship. They worshipped on Sunday, because it was the day their Saviour rose from the dead. They worshipped in the Eucharist because they tried to obey their Master. And there you have the one fundamental characteristic of the day, the one truly Catholic element in the observance of Sunday. For fifteen centuries, wherever the Church of Christ was found, among all the diverse nationalities of East and West, you have a weekly gathering for united worship, finding its highest expression in the service commanded by our Lord.

"There is no rule for Sunday observance, either in Scripture or history; but there is one unvarying custom of Eucharistic worship. Shall we be content with

there is one unvarying custom of Eucharistic worship. Shall we be content with this, and say that what was enough for the early Christians ought to be enough for us, and that all that is needed to keep Sunday properly is to share in the Eucharist? This conclusion seems to me misleading and dangerous. For one thing, it is not true that the early Christians did nothing more than celebrate the Eucharist on Sunday. We gather that they held meetings in which prayer and teaching and mutual exhortation found a place. And besides this, we must remember that history records a development. Sunday in the 20th century is not the Sunday of the primitive Church. We must deal with it as it is, not as it was. It is the tree that matters, not the seed from which it sprang. Through the guidance of the Holy Spirit, Sunday has become more to the Church than it used to be. It has grown in strength and usefulness. It was not originally a day of rest, but it has become so, and from this new fact there come new possibilities and new duties. At the present day it is one of the main safeguards of our religious life, and I want you to see why it is so. Consider what life is to most of us to-day. Never before was the strain of life so great. We do so many things, we receive so many impressions in a short time; the social structure is so complicated; the competitive struggle is so severe. Even if we succeed in the struggle, we have no sense of security. One false step, or indeed some happening beyond our control, may bring us to failure or unemployment. And just now we have the special difficulties of the war and post-war periods. It is not surprising that our over-strained nerves are demanding large doses of amusement and excitement, so large that they increase the malady they are meant to cure. There is another point to be remembered. Never before was life so interesting. Each day we learn from the newspapers the story of the world, and whatever our tastes may be, whether for politics or sport or science or industry or crime, we can find something to occupy our attention. And these three aspects of our modern life, the strain of the struggle, the consequent craving for exciting pleasures, the occupation of the mind by interesting topics, have this in common—that they concentrate our attention on the world that is seen, and obscure the vision of the unseen. This is obvious in the case of the man who devotes his energies to making money or to amusing himself. But it is equally true of the man who is absorbed in history or science, or politics. Their life is secularised. The thought of God, the problems of good and evil, the highest and deepest things are put aside, and if they are touched at all, they are touched by a mind which has already wearied itself over things of less importance. It is not peculiar to this age, but it is the special temptation of this age, the temptation to live on the surface, to ignore the facts and forces which lie beneath, to be content with the secular. But in the wisdom of God a way of escape has been provided by the institution of Sunday. By custom and law our daily work is set aside. We have a chance to get free for a time from material needs.

"To come back, then, to our practical problems. What advice as to Sunday observance shall we give to parents with young families? Without hesitation I should advise two things. First, bring them to Church. A great deal of nonsense has been talked about the evil effects of compulsory church-going. Many tell us that they

ed about the evil effects of compulsory church-going. Many tell us that they never go to church now because when children they were too often forced to go. There are such cases, no doubt. But for every one who has been driven to revolt by excessive strictness, I could point to ten who thankfully acknowledge that their present habit of attendance is based on habits formed in childhood. It was no hardship then, now it is a joy. And for the average child to be brought, not sent, to church, once a Sunday, is no hardship, and provokes no resentment. I wonder if the advocates of freedom are always consistent. When it becomes the custom for the child to choose for himself whether he shall go to his day-school or stay at home, and when this custom has proved beneficial to mind and character, I shall listen with more patience to the plea that a reluctant child should never be taken by his parents to church. And the second point is this. In some way make your children realise that Sunday is meant to be different from other days. It needs only some new duty, some slight restriction as to work or reading or play; a restriction which it might not be easy to justify logically. But the seed-thought is implanted that Sunday is a day with a special history and a special object, and we may leave to later years the application of this thought. But what advice shall we give to adolescents, exulting in their freedom, yet conscious of responsibility. We can say to each of these: You are a member of the Christian Church, a great brotherhood bound together by a supernatural life, and therefore you must not only worship God in private, but you must go to church to make this brotherhood more real to yourself and others. You are pledged to be a faithful servant of the Lord Jesus, and therefore you must do what He commands, and take your part in the Christian Eucharist.

THE TURN OF THE TIDE.

The neglect of Sunday is one of the many disquieting symptoms of our age. It is easy to point to others. But has there ever been an age of the Christian era without its disquieting symptoms, without its evidence that the powers of evil are active, and that Christianity can only win its way through faithful witness and stubborn conflict? Has there ever been an age in which the faint-hearted did not give way to despair? But has there ever been an age in which despair was justified? "Probation worketh hope." Experience has shown that our faith can overcome the world. There is a silly optimism which underrates the power of evil, and ignores the facts of weakness and failure. But there is a still more silly pessimism which recognises and exaggerates every defeat, and

can accept no evidence of victory. We must train ourselves to face all the facts. And I want to remind you of some of the hopeful signs of the present day. It is true that the church shows much feebleness, that its direct influence on the great movements of human life is far below what it ought to be, that men treat it with indifference and contempt. But it is also true that the church is more alive than it has been for a thousand years, that its standards are higher, that an increasing number of its members realise their obligations. Take any test you like of its real life. Its missionary activity

their obligations. Take any test you like of its real life. Its missionary activity is developing. The proportion of devout communicants is increasing. The social work of Christians is more intense and widespread."

After referring to the various world movements, the Bishop said:—Analyse the chorus of complaint that rises against the Christian church. Sometimes no doubt it indicates a revolt against Christianity itself, against its revelation and its morals. But is it not the main charge against us that we are not true to our faith; not that Christ is a deceiver, but that we do not understand Him or obey Him? The world is seeking for Christ, and often the cry of disappointment is bitter because His church does not reveal Him more clearly. Surely it is a hopeful sign when the church is blamed by the world, not for being Christ-like, but for not being Christ-like enough. Let me, in support of my own judgment, quote the words of one who has been a leader and a critic of church life in England and in South Africa; one who saw all the horrors of the war, who was brought face to face with the problems and perplexities, the doubts and the questionings, of those who endured the worst. He has written a book entitled "The Returning Tide of Faith." In his preface he says: "The title was suggested to me by Matthew Arnold's 'Dover Beach.'"

"The sea of faith
Was once, too, at the full, and round
Earth's shore

Lay like the folds of a bright girdle
furled,

But now I only hear
Its melancholy long withdrawing roar,
Retreating to the breath
Of the night wind down the vast edges
drear

And naked shingles of the world.
"Such was the verdict of the Victorian poet. But the ebb-tide of faith has turned. The Christian faith is coming again. Such—despite the many disappointments and perplexities of to-day—is my conviction."